

Science and the Fallible B.S. Detector

RALPH ESTLING

Someone once asked Ernest Hemingway what he thought was a writer's most important tool. Hemingway knew straight off. "An infallible bullshit detector," he answered. He didn't specify the range the detector should have, I suspect, because he saw no reason to limit its range or the exact type and species of B.S. it was meant to detect. Detecting B.S. is detecting B.S., I guess he figured, no matter its source, location, and espouser.

We have no excuse for erecting limits, drawing boundaries, citing no-go areas. We must deal skeptically, critically, not only with the irrational—claims of paranormality and all that—but, and far more important for the field of intellectual development, with claims that are utterly and entirely rational. This second kingdom of inquiry includes science and all its works. The testing of scientific claims is manifestly more worthy of our time and consideration (both being limited for mortals) than claims of an irrational, unscientific sort can ever be.

Belief in paranormal and supernatural beings, forces, and events is not an especially essential statement about the nature and manifestation of things, and for this reason skeptical inquiries into these, while often desirable, are rarely essential. But when we are faced with affirmations by qualified, or seemingly so, scientists based on scientific methodologies—for example, that the universe had a beginning in time and that this beginning had its ultimate cause in this or that cosmologic occurrence and process, or was totally without cause, possessing effects only—then it behooves us to sit up, take notice, and think. This much for starters. After this, we must engage in observational tests of the claim. If observational tests are not possible, then we are thrown back to logical/mathematical surmises, which are not nearly as good as determining the truths our skeptical souls hanker after.

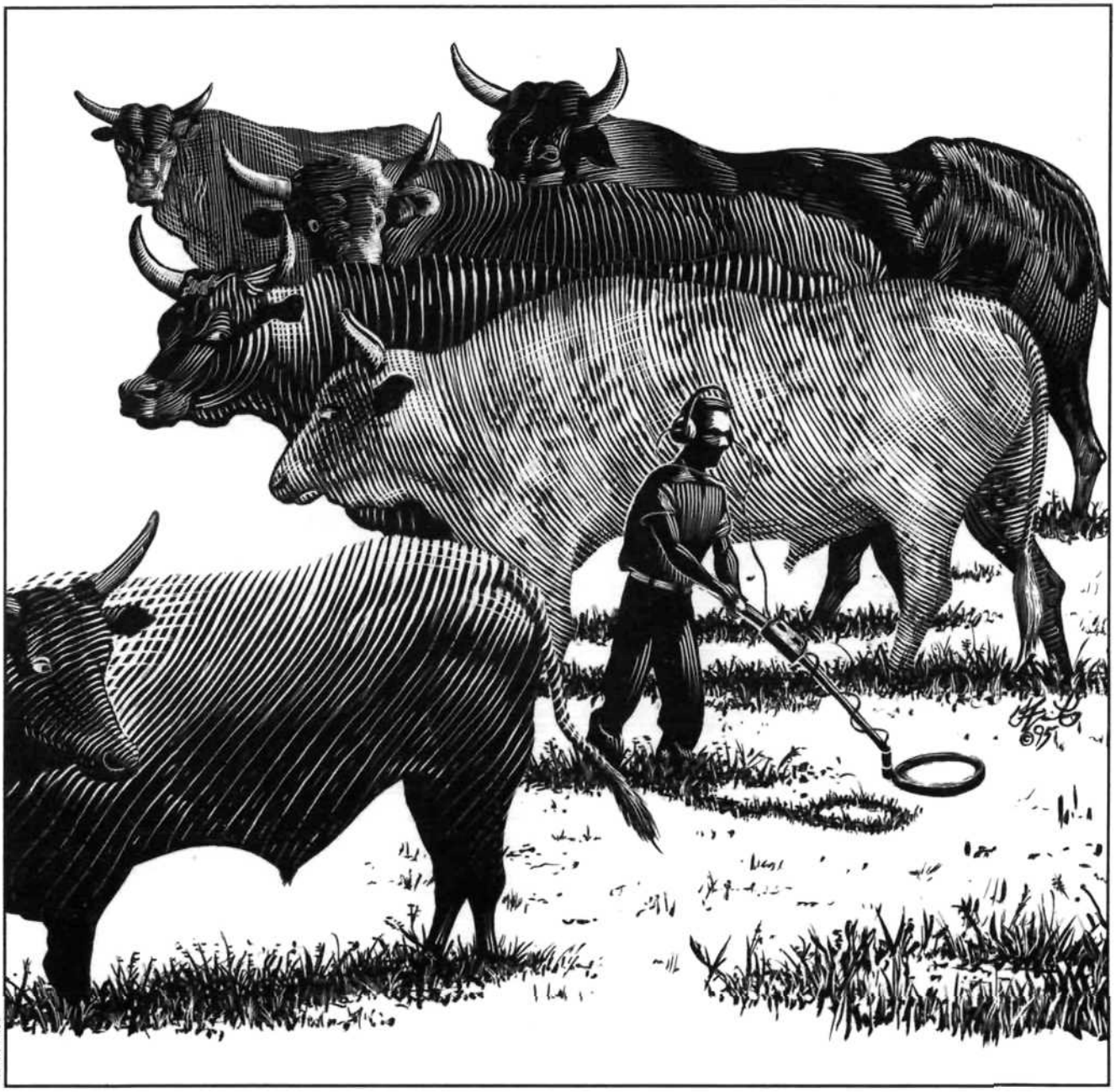
For all of this, rational and irrational claims alike, we need that wonderful machine, the infallible B.S. detector. Sadly, this is an imperfect world, and so, such an agent of truth does not yet exist. Until it does, we must rely on that fallible device, our brain.

The brain is desirable in two ways: for acquiring information and for assessing it. Both functions are essential. We must first acquire information so that it can be assessed. But if we acquire it without assessing it, we are likely to contribute nothing to the world except a lifetime's manure.

Our brain's unquestionable fallibility is a source of deep disquiet to us. This disquiet is a good thing, for without it, we run the risk of confusing ourselves with God. If we keep the distinction clearly in mind, our brains can be useful instruments in humanity's ongoing battle with B.S. of all constituencies, breeds, and distinctions—the common variety of everyday encounters, or the uncommon and often startlingly marvelous sort of the poets, priests, and philosophers, and yes, the scientists. This is often quite beautiful and, being beautiful, detecting its true nature is harder, and from an aesthetic point of view, a rude, vulgar, and thoroughly beastly thing to do.

I have been accused of being beastly to scientists, a grave charge. However, the accusation is fair, if I add the qualification "some." I have also been informed I am antiscience, the logic being that if I criticize some scientists for some of their remarks this is because I fear and hate science and wish it ill. Similarly, a parent telling a child to be good rather than wicked, and wise rather than foolish, does so because the parent fears, hates, and is out to destroy the child.

If the human race, this "damned human race," as Mark Twain called it, is to realize salvation, and I'm not sure it is, that salvation will lie in science and in no other realm of human intellectual activity. Science is not only an



Gerald Fried

intellectual force; it is as emotional and as spiritual as any other mentally derived function in which human beings engage their brains. I think the truths revealed by science—and I use the word *truths* deliberately, for *facts* or *information* or *data* do not carry the weight, the *gravitas* I want—matter far more than the comforts of religion, philosophy, and poetry all put together. What's more, I think science is *more* beautiful than they, with their evasions and quarter-truths. For science treats us like grown-ups, and I think we ought to like that.

Not all scientists are grown-ups. Some are remarkably childish, and I see them as betrayers of science. Some do not betray science so much as totally misapprehend it, what it means, what it is here for. I don't suppose that scientists, as a class, are more stupid than other people. But I'm disappointed that they don't appear much less so. Perhaps I expect too much from them.

Meanwhile, my fallible, clanking B.S. detector remains the only weapon I have against the deluge. I wish it were infallible, but for all its shortcomings, defects, and failures, I wouldn't be without it, not for all the peace of mind, peace of soul, and joy of heart I am offered in its stead by the spin doctors of the spirit, not even if I were to be taken up to some very high place where I could behold all the kingdoms of this world, and of the next, and were offered them in exchange.

And if there is a next, I won't want to go there, not unless they let me take my detector along with me. Even there. Even then. □

Ralph Estling writes from Ilminster, Somerset, U.K.